



MALAYSIA

Capital cities: Kuala Lumpur, Putrajaya
Area: 127,316 sq miles (329,750 sq km)
Population: 24,400,000
Official language: Malay
Major religions: Muslim 53%, Buddhist 19%, Chinese faiths 12%, Hindu 7%, Christian 7%, traditional beliefs 2%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Ringgit
Adult literacy rate: 89%
Life expectancy: 73 years
People per doctor: 1,474
Televisions: 166 per 1,000 people

SINGAPORE

Capital city: Singapore
Area: 267 sq miles (693 sq km)
Population: 4,300,000
Official languages: Malay, Chinese, Tamil, and English
Major religions: Buddhist 55%, Taoist 22%, Muslim 16%, other 7%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Singapore dollar
Adult literacy rate: 93%
Life expectancy: 78 years
People per doctor: 698
Televisions: 348 per 1,000 people

Half of all cars sold in Malaysia are Protons.

MALAYSIA

SPREAD ACROSS THE SOUTH CHINA SEA is the divided land of Malaysia. Part of the country lies on the Malay Peninsula, which hangs off the corner of mainland Southeast Asia, but the states of Sarawak and Sabah are on the island of Borneo to the east. More than 24 million people live in the country, most of them in the rapidly growing cities on the peninsula. Every five years Malaysia gets a new head of state: nine sultans, who each rule one of the states that make up the country, take turns acting as king.



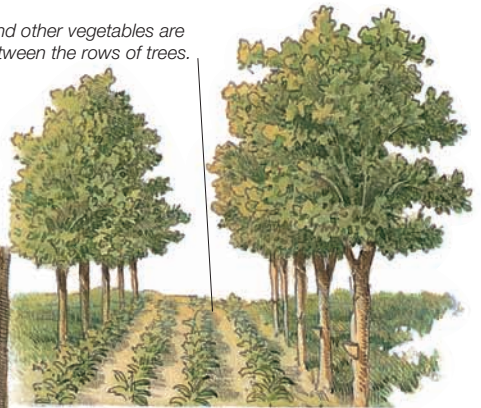
NATURAL RESOURCES

Malaysia is rich in natural resources, with large oil and gas reserves off the coast of Sarawak. The country is the world's top producer of palm oil, used to make soap and for cooking, and the third biggest producer of natural rubber. The rain forests of Sarawak are rich in hardwood trees, but experts are worried that the logging industry is cutting down trees faster than the forest can renew itself.



Peas, beans, and other vegetables are often grown between the rows of trees.

Strips of bark are cut away to let the latex run down the trunk and into a collecting cup.



RUBBER

Hidden inside the bark of the rubber tree is a white liquid, called latex, that is used to make natural rubber. Rubber trees grow in hot, wet climates and flourish on the lower slopes of the mountains that run down the length of the Malay Peninsula. Collected latex is sent to a local factory. There it is mixed with water and acid in a large pan to make a sheet of rubber that is then smoked or hung on a line to dry.

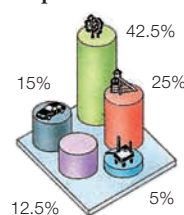
Rubber tappers go out before dawn to collect the latex before the high daytime temperatures stop its flow.

THE CHANGING ECONOMY

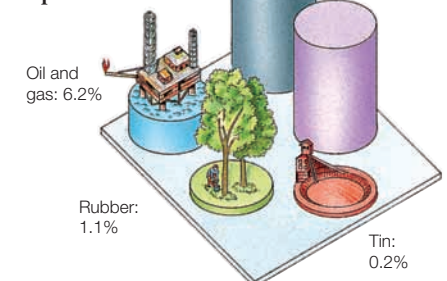
1970s: in 1970, Malaysia had few factories, and most of its raw materials, such as rubber and tin, were exported to be manufactured into finished goods abroad.

2000s: today, Malaysia's economy is one of the most successful in the world. Malaysia continues to produce large amounts of raw materials, and its manufacturing sector has grown dramatically. Three-quarters of all exports are now finished goods, such as cars, electronics, textiles, and foods.

Exports in 1970



Exports in 1998



MODERN INDUSTRY

The first car to be manufactured in Malaysia – the Proton – rolled off the production line outside Kuala Lumpur in 1985. Today, more than 90,000 Protons are produced every year, many for export to Indonesia, Singapore, and the UK. The Proton has been so successful that it has been followed by a second car project, the Perodua. Malaysia is also an international center for the electronics industry and is the world's biggest producer of disk drives for computers.



THE PEOPLE OF MALAYSIA

Almost half the population of Malaysia are Malays, like this family. About one-third are Chinese; the rest are either descendants of settlers from the Indian Subcontinent or local tribespeople. This mix of peoples has led to racial conflict in the past.